MOREH NEVUCHIM

Up, Down & Sitting in the Torah: What Motion Means for Hashem

Given Tuesday 7 July 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim §1 · Ch 10–11

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** 1 · Chapters 10 & 11 **Topic:** The Terms עלה & ירד (Descending & Ascending) and ישיבה (Sitting) in Torah **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Where We Are

Chapters	Terms Treated
1–4	Tzelem/Demut · Temunah/Tavnit · the verbs of seeing
5	Caution approaching the divine (the burning bush; the nobles)
6–7	Ish/Isha · Yalad (Ma'aseh Bereshit)
8–9	**Makom** (place) · **Kisei** (throne)
10–11 (tonight)	**Yarad/Alah** (down & up) · **Yeshiva** (sitting)

The project continues: terms that *seem* to ascribe physicality or position to Hashem — reread correctly.

PART 1 — Chapter 10: עלה and ירד (Ascending and Descending)

Rambam's Opening Note — Why These Terms Are Here

כבר הקדמנו שאנחנו מזכירים בפרקי הספר הזה כל מונח שיש בו שיתוף — we treat only **multi-meaning (homonymous) terms** that risk being misunderstood about God.

(He is not writing a dictionary — only defusing the dangerous words.)

The Two Literal Meanings

Term	Literal Meaning
ירד (yarad)	Moving from a higher place to a lower place — physical descent
עלה (alah)	Moving from a lower place to a higher place — physical ascent

The Borrowed Meaning — Status and Rank

Just as with *makom* (Ch. 8), the terms were borrowed for **greatness and status**:

"When a person's **standing declines** — we say he "descended הושאלו שני מונחים אלו לגדולה ולכבוד (ירידה); he "ascended **standing rises** — "when his (עלייה).

The Torah's Examples

Verse	Usage
הגר בקרבך יעלה עליך מעלה מעלה, ואתה תרד מטה מטה (the Tochacha)	The stranger will rise higher and higher over you, and you will descend lower and lower — **status**, not stairs
ירוד ירדנו (Yosef's brothers)	"We have surely declined"

Modern Hebrew Preserves This

עולה לארץ / עלייה — one who moves to Eretz Yisrael "ascends" (a rise in spiritual status)

יורד — "one who leaves Israel "descends

עלייה לתורה — being called *up* to the Torah (an honor — status) *(Even in English: "moving up in the world," "a step down.")*

Applied to Hashem — Three Distinct Usages

Usage 1 — Prophecy: The Prophet "Ascends," the Shefa "Descends"

When the term relates to **prophecy and apprehension**:

עלייה — the prophet's **ascent of the mind** toward apprehension

ירידה — the descent of the **divine overflow (shefa)** onto the prophet

Examples:

וירד ה' על הר סיני — "Hashem descended on Har Sinai" = the prophetic revelation descended; **not** God moving down

עלה אלי ההרה — "ascend to Me on the mountain" = rise in apprehension (though Moshe also physically climbed — remember the rule: **the literal stays unless there's reason to remove it**; the physical climb is real, and the deeper meaning rides on it)

וירד ה' לראות את העיר ואת המגדל — Hashem "descended to see" the city and tower: **His knowledge engaged the lowly deeds of men**, not spatial motion (Bavel)

Usage 2 — Punishment: "Descent" Before Striking the Low

When Hashem is described as "descending" toward punishing a people:

ירידה here = the turning of the divine attention **downward** toward those who have made themselves low ("I will descend and see" — **ארדה נא ואראה** — Bavel; Sedom).

(And the deeper lesson of ארדה נא ואראה — see below: judges must not rule on hearsay.)

Usage 3 — The Shechinah's "Descent" to a Place

to a mountain or the Mishkan — the settling of the divine presence/glory upon a location: a **ירידת השכינה** **manifestation**, not movement of God (who has no body and no place — Ch. 8).

The Beautiful Derash — "I Will Descend and See" (Sedom)

ארדה נא ואראה: הכצעקתה הבאה אלי עשו — כלה; ואם לא — אדעה

Does Hashem need to "go down and check"?! Obviously not — He knows all. The Midrash (quoted by Rashi):

He taught judges never to rule in capital matters except לימד לדיינים שלא יפסקו דיני נפשות אלא בראייה **by direct examination** — not by report, not by rumor.

If the Omniscient One "descends to see" before judging Sedom — a human judge certainly may not condemn on hearsay. *(A model of Hashem performing pedagogy through the Torah's very phrasing.)*

PART 2 — Chapter 11: ישיבה (Sitting)

The Literal Meaning

תחילת קביעתו של המונח הזה בלשוננו היא ישיבת האדם על המקום — a person settling on a place. Sitting.

The Borrowed Meaning — Stability, Permanence, Unchangingness

הושאל מונח זה **לכל מצב יציב קבוע שאינו משתנה** Borrowed for **any stable, fixed, unchanging state.**

Why? Think about what sitting *is*: **standing is effortful and temporary; sitting is settled.** A person who sits has come to rest — stability.

The Example — Yerushalayim

ורבתי עם... ישבה בדד :And the promise (Eicha — appropriate as we approach Tisha B'Av) **על מקומה** " — **וירושלים עוד תשב** Yerushalayim will yet **sit** in her place" = **will endure, established and unchanging.**

Applied to Hashem — The Unchanging One

אתה ה' לעולם תשב "You, Hashem, **sit** forever" — (Eicha 5) **ישב בשמים** He who sits in the" — (Tehillim) "heavens

"Sitting" applied to Hashem = His absolute permanence and unchangeability — לא מצד עצמו ולא מצד יחסו לזולתו:

1. **He does not change in Himself** — no aging, no development, no mood-shifts
2. **He does not change in relation to anything else** — His relationship to the cosmos is constant

Combined with **kisei** (Ch. 9): "Hashem sits on the throne" = the Unchanging One in His majesty — **not** a seated figure on furniture.

The Rambam's Closing Cross-Reference

The full meaning of "sitting" as applied to God will deepen later (when treating God's knowledge and unity). For now: whenever Tanakh says Hashem "sits" — read **permanence, stability, immutability.**

The Verse That Ties It All Together

"He who sits in the heavens laughs" — (Tehillim 2) **ישב בשמים ישחק**

The nations rage and conspire (**למה רגשו גוים**) — and He who *sits* — the Stable, Unchanging One, unthreatened and unmoved — "laughs." Their plots change nothing in Him. **The metaphor of sitting carries the entire theology: God's unshakeable constancy over against human turbulence.**

Tonight's Summary

Chapter 10 — Yarad & Alah

- Literal: physical descent/ascent → Borrowed: **decline/rise in status** (the Tochacha; aliyah to Israel; aliyah laTorah)
- Applied to God: (1) **prophecy** — the shefa "descends," the prophet's mind "ascends" (Sinai); (2) **judgment** — attention turned to those made low by their deeds (Bavel, Sedom); (3) the **Shechinah's** settling on a place

  judges must see, not rely on hearsay → ארדה נא ואראה
- The literal meaning remains where nothing forces its removal (Moshe really climbed)

Chapter 11 — Yeshiva

- Literal: sitting → Borrowed: **any stable, fixed, unchanging state** (ישבה בדד; עוד תשב על מקומה)
- Applied to God: **אתה ה' לעולם תשב** — He is unchanging in Himself and in His relations

  the Unmoved One over the raging nations — ישב בשמים ישחק

Coming Up Next Week

Chapter 12 (**קימה** — standing/rising) and onward — continuing the lexicon of motion and posture applied to the divine.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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